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Ariel #ShareTheLoad: Integrated Marketing Communication Campaign

Introduction

It was a warm Monday morning, and Mr. Pankaj Srivastav [a pseudonym], marketing head for Procter & Gamble's premium laundry detergent brand, Ariel, was in his office reviewing the monthly sales reports. He was specifically interested in the figures tracking the success of P&G's #ShareTheLoad campaign. Launched in 2015, Ariel's #ShareTheLoad campaign addressed gender equality. The core message, that doing laundry was not necessarily restricted to a particular gender, aspired to drive behavioural change. The campaign had been running since 2015, and while the core message remained the same, the overall communication was given fresh impetus at different stages. The campaign was so successful that several years later, in 2021, it continued to attract millions of views and resonate with customers. Pankaj, however, was in a quandary. He was apprehensive that the campaign message would lose its impact. Concerned about losing market share, he called his branding and media relations team in for consultations. "How long could Ariel sustain this campaign, as every product, every campaign has its own lifecycle? What was the future plan for the campaign? Would a renewed campaign translate into market share?" There was cause for concern despite the campaign's success because it remained to be seen whether it would continue to enhance brand perception and generate higher revenue by attracting new customers, while still retaining the loyal ones.

Laundry Care Market in India

Valued at INR 302.2 billion, the laundry care market in India experienced a healthy retail value growth of 4% in 2020 and was expected to grow at a good pace. Detergent giants, Hindustan Unilever (HUL) dominated the Indian market as a clear market leader with around 43% of market share in terms of sales value in the retail market. In the international market, however, Procter & Gamble (P&G) was the market leader. In the Indian premium detergent market, there were basically two front runners, Ariel and Surf Excel. P&G wanted to put all its resources into capturing all segments in the Indian detergent market. P&G was successful in doing this in the case of Tide, where it promoted Tide as a natural product against Rin of Unilever to successfully increase its market share in that segment. HUL, in the Rin washing powder television commercial, described as the new fight in the biggest soap opera (<https://www.hindustantimes.com/business/rin-ad-goes-against-the-tide-of-convention/story-2AKXuGzbRgC31OSqKLve7L.html>), openly displays the rival pack Tide Naturals and claims that their product is qualitatively superior to Tide. The voiceover message, "*Tide se kahin behatar safedi de Rin*," translates to "Rin gives better whiteness than Tide" (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=HAEb2UmA_w8).

In this detergent war, however, P&G was not able to deflect HUL's blow, especially as far as Ariel was concerned. In this case, P&G was struggling to increase its market share in India in the premium segment (Exhibits 1, 2, and 3).

Ariel #ShareTheLoad Movement: Various Campaigns

Ariel launched this campaign in 2015 with the intent to address gender inequality vis-à-vis household chores in the Indian society. Its message was very clear—doing laundry was not limited to a particular gender. It was

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promoted in different ways at different stages. The brand wanted to focus on the fact that the quality and the performance of the product were so good that anybody could use it to do their laundry. In this way, it promoted gender equality in household chores and the product itself very effectively. Initially, when this programme was launched, 79% of men thought that laundry was a woman's job. When this figure dropped to 52% in 2016, it was attributed to the success of this campaign. The biggest achievement was the increase in sales volume that the brand experienced and the positive sentiment with which consumers engaged with the brand. The campaign gained 73 million views nationally, with the reach of approximately 80% in the desired target group.

In 2016, P&G came up with a new version of this campaign, Dads#ShareTheLoad, which focused on the message that children of the house learn from what they see and observe. As many of them had not seen their fathers doing the laundry, they learned that men didn't do laundry. When Ariel initiated this campaign, it wanted fathers to be role models for their children.

Buoyed by its success, P&G came up with the next instalment, Sons#ShareTheLoad. Here, Ariel wanted to address social discrimination in the context of teaching children about household chores. P&G, through their campaign, wanted to show that sons could also do laundry, as this activity was not limited to just one gender. In fact, all members of the household should be responsible for contributing to this. Ariel wanted to target this issue and initiate a conversation on this subject. They created a video where the mother realises her mistake in not teaching her son to share domestic chores. Distraught that her daughter is giving up her job because she is unable to cope with domestic and professional pressure, the mother gently puts the pile of dirty laundry in her son's hands. Her symbolic gesture shows her as a changemaker in society (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8QDlv8kfwIM>).

In 2019, Marc Pritchard, P&G's global chief brand officer, even discussed this topic at the gender equality panel at the World Economic Forum in Davos (<https://www.forbesindia.com/article/m.a.d-marketing-advertising-decoded/how-josy-paul-nourished-ariels-share-the-load-campaign/61189/1>; <https://www.campaignasia.com/agencyportfolio/CaseStudy/377,ariel--sons-sharetheload.aspx#.YRcY0c0zbDc>).

Current Campaigns

Creative Brief to the Agency

Worldwide, P&G was a leader in the premium detergent segment. However, to move up from its position at No. 2 in India, P&G needed to expand its customer base to include men and children, not just women, who traditionally were considered the knowledgeable customers of laundry products. Thus, to resonate with everyone regardless of their gender or age, P&G used the emotional hook of the two most important bonds that a human being develops: the parent-child bond, and the husband-wife bond.

Against this background, P&G's fabric care brand, Ariel, rolled out the fourth chapter of the #ShareTheLoad campaign in 2019. The new ad, launched across social media and digital platforms, sought to highlight the impact of the unequal division of household chores on women's well-being, and leverage this to encourage men to step into a domain hitherto restricted exclusively for women. Conceptualised by the advertising agency, BBDO, the ad takes the perspective of a little girl, who, thus far, is untouched by any social conditioning. Having awakened, she notices that her mother is not next to her, though it is late at night. Rubbing her eyes with sleep, she goes from room to room in her father's arms in search of her mother and finds her asleep in front of the washing machine with a load of dirty laundry. Tired and sleepy, her mother had been working continuously to complete multiple chores. It's a moment of epiphany for the father as he realises that his wife is tired and sleep-deprived in her effort to balance her professional work and her household duties.

In 2020, Ariel rebooted this campaign with a new version of #ShareTheLoad to sensitise society towards the unequal division of domestic work leading to sleep deprivation in women. Lack of sleep was indicative of the existing inequality in the family—a microcosm of society. According to a survey (<https://www.ariel.in/en-in/share-the-load/for-domestic-chores-and-equal-sleep>), 71% of the women in India sleep less than their husbands due to the unequal division of household chores. During the pandemic lockdown, many people worked from home, creating additional stress for the women of the household. This situation further strengthened Ariel's core

message about the existing inequality in sharing household chores, with the brand promoting the idea of equal sleep and, through the campaign, the movement towards greater gender equality.

The objectives given to the agency were intended to help sustain the buzz.

- a. Create recall.
- b. Launch the campaign and create a buzz around it. Promote the latest campaign thought/video across all verticals and initiate the conversation.
- c. Drive change in the behaviour of people through PR, events, social media, influencers, marketing associations, etc.
- d. Sustain the buzz and culmination—brand collaborations, concept-driven events, and a pan-India approach.

Implementation of #ShareTheLoad campaign—Media Vehicles Used

P&G proposed that a 360-degree approach would have the greatest impact on customer experience. To this end, integration of all media vehicles was suggested, so that not only would the maximum impact be created, but the recall would also be sustained for a longer period. For instance, the campaign targeted towards sons and daughters, the one targeted towards fathers, and the latest one during the pandemic were all released as television commercials. The aim was to focus on the prevailing prejudices in the upbringing of sons and daughters, and urge mothers and fathers to be the changemakers themselves to bring about social change. Through the campaign, the social construct that men were superior to women and, therefore, not required to share household chores was key. According to P&G, the message #ShareTheLoad, vis-à-vis laundry, was symbolic. It was “the face of the movement” to drive gender equality rather than simply an ad campaign. It raises the question that, while mothers were bringing up their daughters to be efficient both outside the home and at home, were they imparting the same values to their sons? Once the target segment was exposed to this inequality, the campaign was promoted on YouTube and then on its Facebook, Twitter, and Instagram accounts to sustain the buzz. #ShareTheLoad thus went on to become one of the most popular hashtags on social media.

One of the strategies used to create recall was to launch a massive PR campaign using contextual issues. Celebrities and influencers participated in massive public events for a social cause, which was then put on social and digital media to create a multiplier effect. The purpose was to create user-generated content. Millions participated in these campaigns.

PR Buzz to Integrate the Campaign

Ariel launched a campaign encouraging men to “Show True Love” by promising the women in their lives that they would #ShareTheLoad. Thus, on Valentine’s Day, traditionally celebrated by giving flowers and gifts to their wives as a token of their love, Ariel launched a #DateWithLaundry campaign, suggesting that it would be more meaningful for men to share the burden of chores with their spouses. To target young children, Ariel collaborated with Sesame Street and the Indian cartoon Galli Galli Sim to spread the message of gender equality. This was seen as a positive move towards sensitising children and nurturing gender equity in them by example.

The detergent company also launched a PR campaign, #LaundryGoesOddEven, when the odd-even car scheme was introduced by the Delhi government in their effort to reduce pollution in the capital. Ariel introduced a new Odd-Even Ariel detergent pack with a calendar reminding men to share the laundry load with the women according to the alternate days designated to them.

To sustain the buzz, the company went a step further by creating offline events. Some of the notable ones were:

- a. Mommy Bloggers Meet, in which around 100 Mommy bloggers participated.
- b. Topical integrations—Women’s Day was celebrated by felicitating mothers who had contributed by teaching their sons to #ShareTheLoad.
- c. Ariel Fabric Care collaborated with Navneet Prakashan to develop gender-equal colouring books.

- d. Ariel partnered with Tinkle, a popular children's comic book, by creating stories of how Tinkle's favourite characters share the load.
- e. Ariel conceptualised SON-Day to motivate sons to share domestic duties. Thus, every Sunday, boys were urged to learn how to do household chores and share responsibilities with the women at home. It used a rap song encouraging them to share the load starting with the laundry.
- f. Ariel curated and sent a #HamperofEquality box to prospective customers, packed with an item for each household member that highlighted the importance of a change in mindset and behaviour, reminding them to share the load of household chores.
- g. For the festival of Holi, Ariel partnered with Whirlpool and modern retail chains like Big Bazaar and Metro Cash & Carry to give men a crash course in doing laundry and, in this way, ensure that the festival was joyous for everyone.

Impact and Measurement of Metric—#ShareTheLoad—A Household Name

This 360-degree view was meant to create buzz and sustain it over time, keeping in view the objectives and mission of the campaign.

Launched in 2015, the campaign continued into 2016 and was very successful, as it went on to create a huge impact by 2020. Ariel's latest campaign, Sons#ShareTheLoad, culminated in Ariel getting the Guinness World Record for the largest laundry lesson imparted to 400 sons at one given point of time. The statistics in the Case Exhibit 5 clearly demonstrate that the campaign not only generated awareness, but was also able to create recall and buzz that resulted in bringing about behavioural change.

The impact metrics of the campaign revealed that a higher percentage of men had realised that domestic chores were also their responsibility, and by sharing the load they showed solidarity to household equality. The emotional equity built for the brand and setting it in context resonated with society. The increased reach of the campaign, its increased penetration, increased digital media reach, created huge user-generated content for P&G's premium detergent brand. It also won with the PR movement and created a sustainable buzz, as is evident in the Case Exhibit 5.

Dilemma

Pankaj, however, was worried. His tension stemmed from the fact that despite hard work and investment in the campaign, Ariel's market share was not increasing. There were constant counterattacks from Surf Excel, with their hugely successful campaign, *Daag Achhe Hain*, which had high emotional connection for their consumers. This had become a war of the detergents for the whitest and the brightest wash, and if Ariel's next campaign flopped, it could put everything in jeopardy. Thus, it was imperative that future campaigns surpass the previous ones.

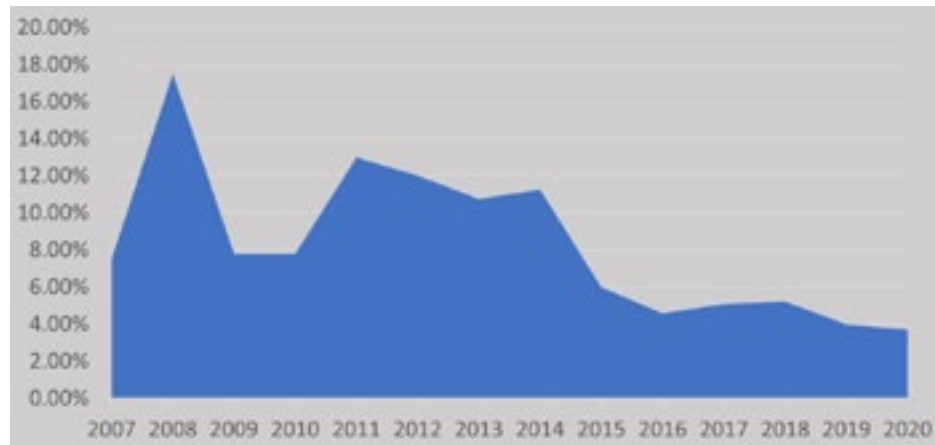
Pankaj recalled the advice of David Ogilvy, known as The Father of Advertising: "Repeat your winners. If you are lucky enough to write a good advertisement, repeat it until it stops selling. Scores of good advertisements have been discarded before they lost their potency" (<https://www.impactplus.com/impact-book-summaries/david-ogilvy-on-advertising>). Pankaj was concerned and uneasy: "How long would the winning advertisement last? Were these winners sustainable in the long run? Would the emotional route taken by #ShareTheLoad backfire in the counterattack of Surf Excel's counterattack, which used an equally strong emotional plank?"

With all these questions coursing through his mind, Pankaj called for a meeting with his marketing staff, his communications manager, and his advertising agency to discuss the working objectives, the communication plan, and the success metrics for the campaign. He realised that it was not enough to create winning advertisements. In the face of so much competition, the key was to capture the imagination of the people and be able to sustain the engagement with them for a long time to come!

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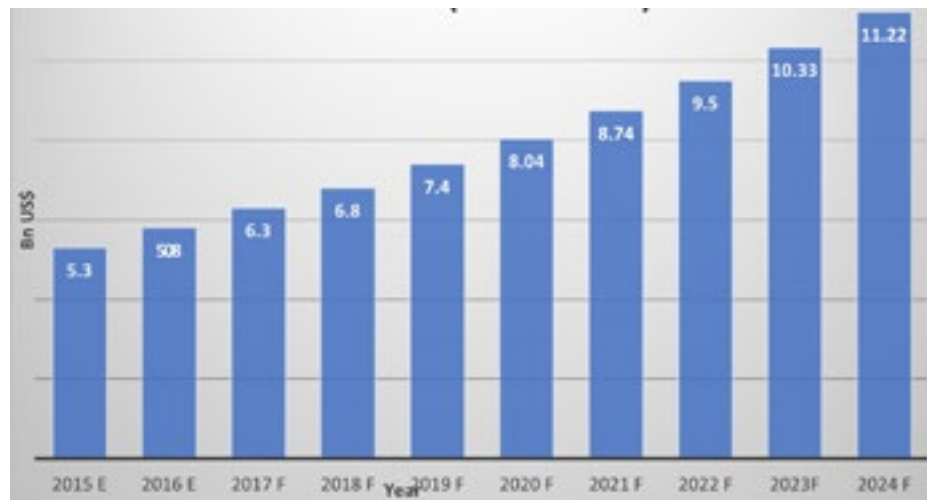
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Exhibit 1. Sales Performance of Laundry Care in India
% Year-on-Year Growth (Retail Sales Price Value)



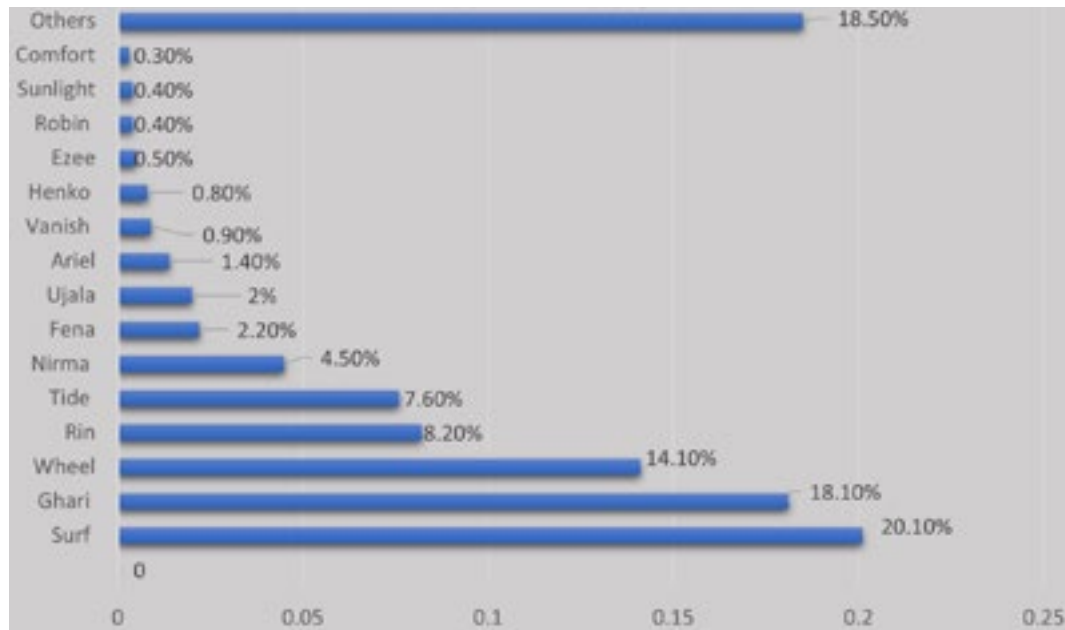
Source: *Euromonitor*, Laundry Care in India, 2021.

Exhibit 2. Laundry Care Market in India
Sales and Growth (Forecasted)



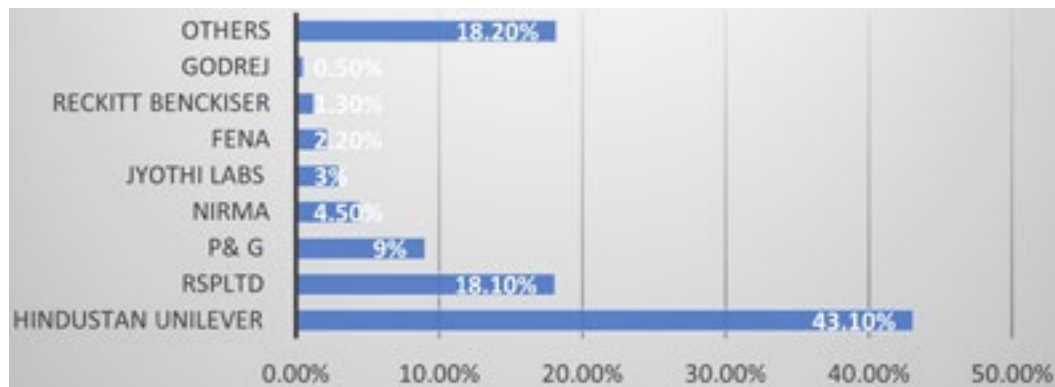
Source: Author's submission, based on data of Laundry Care in India, *Euromonitor*.

Exhibit 3. Brand Share-Laundry Care in India
RSP Retail Value % 2020



Source: *Euromonitor*, Laundry Care in India, 2021.

Exhibit 4. Company-Wide Share Laundry Care in India
% Share (NBO) Resale Value RSP



Source: *Euromonitor*, Laundry Care in India, 2021.

Exhibit 5. Data for Campaign Efficiency

Winning with the Movement

- In 2015, when P&G launched #ShareTheLoad (STL), 79% of men thought household chores were a woman's job. In 2016, this number had dropped to 63%, and in 2019 it had further reduced to 52%.
- Marc Pritchard, P&G's global chief brand officer, discussed this at the gender equality panel at World Economic Forum in Davos in 2019.
- The Sons#ShareTheLoad movement garnered 73MM views nationally. Approximate reach within the Target Group (TG): 80%, Total number of conversations: 45,000.
- Sentiment: 98% positive and neutral.
- Other brands joined in the cause to show their solidarity towards household equality.

Winning with Society

- More men today are sharing the load than ever before.

Winning with Business

- Increasing scores on key equities.
- For the first time ever, Ariel was ranked among Brand Equity's 10 Most Trusted Brands (#7 vs #44).
- Impact across Path to Purchase.
- Unaided Brand Awareness (UBA) increase 13% pre-STL vs after-STL.
- Consideration increases 21% pre-STL vs after-STL.
- Offtake (sales) increase 125 Index vs Year Ago (IYA) on value.
- Penetration up 11% vs year ago.
- Share up 11% vs year ago with growing share of all states.
- Engagement rate increased 5X (STL vs non-STL posts).

Winning with PR

- 45 cities in India were activated to spread the campaign and generate media coverage.
- Various mommy communities were tapped to spread the message to mothers, who are the real changemakers of society—Babychakra, Universe of Mumbai Moms (UNIMO), Kidsstoppress, Momspresso, First Moms Club.
- #ShareTheLoad equality kit was distributed to bloggers, who did social media posts, and thus initiated the conversation.
- Celebrity interviews were done to spread the message and the campaign.
- Coverage Summary Total PR Value in Dollars, INR (in 000s) Total impressions (to date) 6,129.63 (USD) 1.5 Bn. 99,039 (INR)

Source: <https://www.campaignasia.com/agencyportfolio/CaseStudy/377,ariel--sons-sharetheload.aspx#.YIWqaO4zbIV>.